

Dreadful *her.*

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Chapter 1:

THE Beginnings

Forest was dark around the pavement of that long road.
Dark Night has spread fully demonstrating the midnight.
Full moon could be seen from hustling of leaves. A long road showing barely large building lights like little stars a huge silence enveloping the surroundings with no trace of any living thing there
Far . somewhere ... the silence shattered by the thuds of running steps , stumbling ones there was howling of animals which ones? she couldn't guess ... how could she when

She was running hysterically Disheveled hair barely showing that it might was comb this evening neatly into a braid, now it was nowhere near a braid..... White dress was torn from behind and the torn piece of cloth was flapping with each and every thud , she didn't know where to go, her mouth bleeding on the upper right corner of her lips ,

the gloss was showing on a few places mixed with dark red crimson blood stains...

like this evening she pulled the drawer sitting in front of the mirror put out the gloss -- his favorite shade of pink, she smiled and put that on in a fragile manner
She rubbed her lips brutally running, the blood left its dark red shade on the back of her hand she didn't bother it ... she couldn't , she knew one thing , just Running and Running ...

“Stop!! You Bitch!!” – He shouted from a distance lingering on one foot ... bleeding foot. And suddenly his pace got quicker ... **“You Wouldn't be leaving this – (He spitted blood from his mouth on his left) – ALIVE , YOU ----- ”** ... The sound started coming nearer and nearer from her back.

She tried to run faster but with a thud on her shoulder, ---- she fell down on her knees. In no time, He crawled over her,

“(He Laughed like a monster) HUH , What Now! --- ” , She could not understand what he was saying next.

She was helpless, struggling with senses going numb, hands losing their power to struggle

and the mind, the heart couldn't focus anymore She barely looked at the monster shouting something on her and then her gaze moved ... on the left of his head was The Sky

Her eyes were already not giving a visible view with blurry sight ... brain pounding hard with the walls ...

heart racing frantically ...

senses going Numb, ...

the only thing she knew was,,,

There was THE Sky

He saw the Sky with a Blurry sight, the dizziness was still lingering somewhere in the eye corners ... he was on a comfy sofa on terrace and he had no idea when did his eyes got weary and shut down while working Laptop was on a bistro table with an empty coffee mug beside it ... he sit straight brushing his eyes slightly and looked at his watch ... He missed Fajr again today ... a strange kind of grief hit him ...

After praying fajr and getting ready for office by 11 , he stepped out of his room ... looking on the door beside his ..

There was slight knocking on the door. She quickly closed the Book she was reading and in swift motion placed it under her pillow, when the door was open, she was already found in a peaceful sleep, ... well maybe she just assumed ..

He slowly stepped towards the bed and stood right beside her ... he sighed with soft gaze and in a soft tone almost whispering -- "**Perfect ...**".

She could hear the footsteps going away and slightly opened her one eye ... he was standing in front of the dressing;
she could see his back .. wearing a white shirt and black pants one hand was in his side pocket ... , he was placing some tablets there ... and then he brushed his hair and turned .. found her sleep peacefully as before , he chuckled and stepped out of the room closing the door with a thud.

She quickly got up sitting straight looking at the table where the headache tablets were placed showing something she was ignoring for days,

"Why do I care!" With her usual nonchalant behavior she didn't bother standing up and take a look. Just took the Novel out and started the suspense story she was reading earlier unaware of that when a door is closed with a thud, it slightly opens ... he was standing there completely amused by her behavior then he left for office with a slight smile.

He was working in the office when his phone started ringing .. the bright screen was showing a picture of him with an older woman , the screen said : "**Biaa Calling**"

“Salaam Biao .. how are you”, No soon has he greeted when a joyous childish voice appeared from behind the screen...

“Mamuu , when .. will you come ... mama just .. punished .. me” , --
he laughed on his way of talking

“Awww , Where is Mama, Mamuu will take your revenge , YES?” ,
The kid on other side showed a much stronger expression by saying **“YESSS”** like his purpose of calling was achieved,
He could hear the behind voices of her elder sister ,

“Sher...Sherry , give me that ... Salaam Ahad , Wait a moment, Sherryyyy .. stop ... I am saying you this very last time .. ”
he was amused by listening all that stuff.

“They are just becoming so stubborn day by day.. How are you and How is Huriya ”. His smile faded a bit

“Well I am great as always and --- (he sighed), and Huriya is a bit --- Strange”. He paused for a moment.

“hmm, I got you ... she would adjust, give her some time. I remember how her laughters used to circle around in our house!.. sher... Sherry ... when I alrea...”.

He wasn't listening to ... what Biao was talking next after associating laughters with her ... his wife who never even smiled since 3 months , since the day they got married ...

besides eating together .. they barely talked and she had laughters? , before ? why don't she laugh now ? Is he the reason? Is she just surviving the decision that was his - alone?

“Ahad?? Are you there??” He suddenly was pulled out of his thoughts

“Umm – Yeah , I .. I just have some work to do.. can we talk later!” ...

“Okay but visit baba this week, He was asking for you and Do give love to Huriya from my side .. okay .. BYee, Take Care Allah Hafiz” –

“Allah Hafiz” - He cut the call and saw Biao's text ,,

“Make Sure to continue giving her a little more care! [Emoji]”. He reacted with a heart and unintentionally scrolled up where he saw the date

--11th May 2021—

Text : **“She is the girl I talked about , Huriya Dastageer”** with a picture of her.

He clicked on the picture and there she was completely unaware that someone had captured that moment forever sitting on a chair with her legs crossed comfortably, not looking at the camera at all but rather staring somewhere in the distance as though something had caught her attention ,
and on her face was a smile so genuine and effortless that for a moment he found himself forgetting everything else around him

A dark hijab framed her bright features gracefully while the evening sunlight rested softly upon her face her light brown eyes seemed alive with something he had not seen in months and the curve of her lips carried a happiness that appeared so natural that it hurt him a little to realize he had never witnessed that version of her himself

One hand was wrapped around her handbag while the other rested near her hijab as though she had been adjusting it at that exact moment and somebody had taken the picture without her knowledge capturing not just her appearance but an entire piece of her personality in a single frame

He zoomed further into the picture
And kept staring Not because she was the kind of woman the world would stop and call *breathtakingly beautiful* nor because she possessed the sort of beauty poets spent lifetimes writing about

But because she looked Perfect. - Comfortable. - Alive. - Genuine.

His eyes softened unconsciously as he continued looking at her picture wondering how many stories were hidden behind those smiling eyes wondering what had stolen that spark away and most of all wondering whether there would ever come a day when she would smile like that in front of him.... Well he decided one thing ... he wouldn't give up on her ... Not on *her*

11th May 2021

She was looking at her brother and his wife from a distance sitting at a cornered chair and honestly speaking, they looked disgustingly perfect together

The way Rayan would lean slightly towards Abiha while talking the way Abiha would smile before he even completed his sentence the way they seemed to exist inside their own little world despite being surrounded by hundreds of people
They looked like one of those couples' people secretly envied and publicly called "Made for Each Other"

A smile found its way onto Huriya's face as she watched them

It was the first family gathering at their house after a fortnight of her brother's marriage and the atmosphere was overflowing with laughter , relatives , children running around and endless congratulations.

And Biao

Well

Biao was amazing.

Not only had she become a wonderful wife for her brother but somehow she had also adopted Huriya as her unofficial best friend

No matter that it had been a love marriage Huriya had always been firmly on her brother's side during the entire battle of convincing their parents

This function was huge

Not only relatives but office colleagues , old friends and distant family acquaintances had also been invited

The entire lawn was glowing beneath warm lights and decorated with white and pink roses that swayed gently with the evening breeze.

At nineteen years oldAnd in the final month of her FSc

Huriya still considered herself far too young to understand how the world actually workedEspecially when it came to things like marriage.

Or men.

Or whatever mysterious disease made people stare at each other and suddenly decide to spend their entire lives together.

She got up to have a drink and reached out the lemonade stand on one side of the huge lawn .. that was decorated for the function with pink and white roses ... Someone walked in beside her and stretched his empty glass.

"Can I get one?" she heard a manly voice and looked up.

A man wearing a black tuxedo .. light beard that suit him and tall with neatly set black hair , smiling and looking at her with something in his eyes,

"Sure!" without a second thought she put the lemonade in his glass through the Jar.

"Hooriya Dastagir? Rayan's Sister I guess?" he sipped from the lemonade looking at her. On hearing her name from a stranger, well a good looking one , she squinted her eyes meeting his gaze .. ***"Yes .. !?"***

"haha , he used to mention you a lot , I didn't know you are a grown up .. I thought you would be this little by his talk " , he gestured with his one hand

("Now how do he expect me to react") – she thought looking around ... maybe her mother calls out or least his only brother could appear but no one was coming to rescue her for now.

"I think my mother needs me .. well see you later then, Enjoy " she finally gathered courage to make an excuse ..

"Later when?" – there was no funny clue in his eyes ... her heart added 5 more heartbeats quickly ..

"What !?" - unintentionally the question slipped .. this was new to her.

"Maybe you didn't mean what you said but ... But I definitely plan on seeing you ... later"

- she could see him step back looking at her and then finally turned towards a group of people

For a moment her brain stopped functioning.

Then restarted.....Then stopped again.

What kind of answer was that? ... Who even says things like that?

"What a Jerk!!" – she said with visible irritation on her face.

The whole function went weird afterwards, she was moving back and forth between her room and the lawn, she didn't want to disappear from the function being the only sister on his brother and she couldn't bear those intense eyes too

she avoided looking at people directly until everyone started to left. She forbad goodbyes with a genuine smile and eventually was caught up by a woman asking about when her studies are going to end... she looked for her mother who was far away sitting with a bunch of other women taking their leaves .. and then her gaze flickered upon him ...

He was standing with his brother and two other men , quite older ones ... they were discussing something .. the man she met earlier had a coat on his one arm and he was talking too Huraira smiling ... suddenly the old man said something and all of them laughed.

He laughed .. her gaze stayed on his layghing face for a little longer than expected, and unexpectedly he looked directly at her .. she stumbled like being caught red-handed.

("WHATT a Jerk You are Hoor ...") , The woman was gone and she was standing alone there ... she quicked her pace towards her room locking the door --- trying the breath evenly.

("You are such a pervert") ... she shut her eyes blaming herself.

("But he is kinda .. handsome though") – she chuckeld

("So what?? Why should I care ") – she came to her dressing unfolding her hijab.

("Maybe He is interested in marrying me") – A small smile creeped on her lips .. she took the hair clip off and her long hair fell like a stream.

("One man looked at me for ten minutes and I have already planned an entire proposal in my head")- A dramatic sigh escaped her.

("Maybe he do the same thing with every other women") – she sighed again

("yes maybe , I am average though") – she looked at her in the mirror ...

("but .. maybe not") – she knocked it off from her head by focusing on getting a peaceful sleep not knowing that it was not possible from now on.

When finally after praying esha , she slipped under her blanket and closed her eyes, his face appeared on the blank screen asking for lemonade , she smiled and opened her eyes slowly,
But suddenly the thoughts hit ...

Perhaps this was the foolishness of teens

The age where a single compliment could stay in your mind for weeks

Where an accidental glance felt intentional Where a smile carried hidden meanings

And where one person looking at you for a few extra seconds was enough for your imagination to begin stitching together an entire future.

Huriya sighed.

Teenagers truly were dangerous creatures when left alone with their thoughts.

("jerk") – she closed her eyes again

Present day

She slightly opened her eyes ... there was a little redness shown by sleep There were no lights in the room, the outside window was open that used to open in the lawn .. she could see the dark night , perfect half-moon from here, she sit up against the back of the bed and clicked ON the lamp on her side , the clock on the front wall was showing 3:13 am ...

she removed the blanket and walked outside the room .. she had forgot the counting the days she was having same wake ups ... she walked towards the sink and did wudu.. and walked back towards the room , she stopped for a while in front of the door next to hers and looked .. The door was closed .. she sighed and walked in her own.

After placing the prayer mat she sat down slowly.

The silence around her was so complete that it felt as though the entire world had stepped back Leaving only her and Allah.

"Allah"

The word escaped her lips softly... Not as a prayer. or a request

But as someone calling the One they loved.

And suddenly her heart felt lighter. Because every believer knows something beautiful

That before we call upon HimHe already knows.

Before tears reach our eyesHe already sees them.

Before pain reaches our lipsHe already understands it.

A smile appeared on her face.

"You are great You know that?" ... The answer came not as a voiceBut as certainty.

The kind certainty only faith brings. And her heart remembered.

("And when My servants ask you concerning Me Indeed I am near.")

Her eyes softened.

"Ya Allah I have spent more than a hundred days trying to outrun a fear that no longer exists and somehow I am still standing at the same place"

A tear slipped down her cheek....**"I know he is a good man"**

Another tear followed. **"I know You sent him into my life for a purpose .. indeed"**

Her voice trembled. ... **"Then what's it , I don't know , you do... right?"**

And another ayah surfaced gently within her heart.

("We know what is in your hearts.")

She chuckled through her tears..... **"You always win arguments"**

The slight chuckle echoed softly in the room....A broken laugh.....But a genuine one.

....

"Inni Uhibbuka Ya Allah"

"I really do."

Her fingers brushed against the prayer mat..... **"And I want to become better for You."**
The tears no longer felt heavy.....The fear no longer felt unbearable.

(*"Indeed, you are in front of eyes and we are seeing you."*) She assumed Him talking to angels , Telling them about her, Telling them He loves her back .. an ayah came to her mind

(*"And Remember me, so I will remember you!"*)

The morning was a bit different than others .. Ahad didn't came out of his room since Fajr has called. .. Usually during Fajr she hear his footsteps but today there was nothing .. they did ate last night as usual then what's it ? Wouldn't he have to pray ? did he went out late at night .. she came out of her room thinking all that and stood right in front of his room.

(Should i? or Should I not? .. But Hoor you just promised Allah to change and you have to answer about the promises you kept --- Okay Okay I am opening , now stop it)...

She knocked her thoughts off by shaking her head and sighed ... with a racing heart placed her hand on the handle of his door .. just then the knob moved on its own and the door opened. He was standing with messy hair and a sleepy face that changed expression on seeing her ..

"Uh. I ... I was Just .."- She swallowed something.

"!!?" – he was questioning with his eyes .. **"Is everything okay?"**

"yes .. I was just concerned ... Your fajr was .. umm .. getting late"

"Oh... ohkay .. you were concerned .. hmm" – he stepped out leaning on the door by his side crossing arms with his usual amusement.

"Now you are awake, I should be .. leaving", she hesitated .. and this is how she always used to avoid THE conversations.

"I couldn't sleep due to office work and my head is still pounding .. it was difficult to get out of the bed for Fajr." He explained seeing her again trying to end a barely started conversation.

"I have the medicine you gave me , if you want I can.. "

"Yes Please," He smiled cutting her sentence. She nodded and headed towards her room

(huff , WHATTT a disguise .. then why did you even stepped out there well, I didn't know this would happen) – she heard the tap water sound from afar , he was already doing wudu .. the Fajr time was going to end soon.

When she returned , the door was open .. she slowly stepped in ...

That Fragrance , she had hardly came to this room 5-6 times in 100 days and she can guess he only uses one Scent .. a few things had changed since her last visit ..

2kg Dumble have been replaced by 5kg one . There was a new stand there placed , a gym stand she guessed .. side table was messy with coffee cup, his MAC and pens , diaries etc .. and in a corner he was praying.

She was looking for some room on side table to place the pain killer when he came towards her folding the prayer mat.

He grabbed water from her hand and took the pain killer from her palm .. In a quick action , he took it.

“Okay ... Take Rest .. I will be leaving.”

“hmm. ” - he nodded knowing they had the longest interaction this week.

“can you - ” She turned to step out and stopped on his words.

“Cook something , I didn’t eat home-cooked for days ... ” He said getting comfortable in his bed .. his head was actually pounding but he didn’t want to let that moment waste. He might could convince her getting out of her shell ..

“Yeah .. Sure” and then she didn’t look back and quickly came to her room closing the door

(“HUH! , What do I do Noww”) ... She started pacing here and there in a quick manner

(“When did you even last cooked ?”) ...

(“Okay Relax .. You can do that”) ... she took a deep breath (“I can do that!”)

“I know he will do that!” – she was saying with pure amusement and something else ... her voice was echoing in the empty hallway and her friends were making a circle around her.

It was their college. A large building was standing behind the staircase they were sitting on. The girls were listening attentively to her with a spark in their eyes.

“You’re being ridiculous Hoor.it was just a ... umm.. a flirty line that meant nothing. ”- one of them tried to through a reality check that didn’t even flinch her mood.

“you are just envious!” - Another one laughed **“because you are the only one who haven’t yet met anyone ... well leave her Hoor , tell us moree!!”** – she seem more excited giving a shut-up call to reality checker.

“huh! Soon I would be engaged and you guys would see a diamond ring here!” – she stretched her hand in a manner that made everyone laugh again.

“well I hope so ..”— the reality checker smirked rolling her eyes.

“what is your problem dude, I know you are a man hater but let her be happy”— someone else interrupted ... Huriya was getting amused by their reactions but there was something deep down in her heart ... something that was asking her to stop ... to not show any amusement over that to step back and run .. run towards what? .. form whom? .. she had no idea ... well maybe she could find out only if ... she wanted to ... But .. she let her amusement win She let her ... desires win over her heart , her inner voice ..

“At least tell us his name .. our future brother-to-be ”- everyone laughed again except the reality-checker who smirked,

“Well, I didn’t know but by Rayan’s Talk I guessed .. he is ” she took a pause and looked at everyone being so attentive like she was exposing Newton’s theory to a science department of NASA.

“Oh Com’onnn” – an impatient one tugged her on her shoulders that made her laugh.

“Well, Mahir Baig!” – and a burst of playful tugs and laughter burst out making the hallway Students stop their conversations and look at the group of girls.

The whole day was delightful. Ahad worked in the office smiling and getting compliments of how fresh he was working today. He took an early leave saying he had dinner plans with his wife and using the word his wife, he was smiling by heart ...

He get into the car , drove his way home and carried a flower bucket with him ... red roses enveloped in black paper ..

“I hope she doesn’t think this is too much” – he talked to himself carrying that bucket while parking his car aside on their home street.

He stepped out of It and walked towards the house ... took a deep breath before standing in front of the house and placed his hand on the door knob .. he rolled it and pushed slightly when he saw the huge black smoke clouds getting out of the Kitchen ..

"What the .. " - his pace quicken towards the kitchen and he wasn't ready for what was waiting inside.

The steel bowl was black by large hot flames enveloping it , whole kitchen was filled with stinging smoke and the unbearable heat.

He quickly placed the bucket on a side shelf ... the flames have gotten the handkerchief hanging by the wall and there was still a bit water inside the steel pot bowling in a frantic way.

He switched off the stove, and groaned when the frantic boiling water flew on his hand ... With stinging pain he picked the towel and put the burning black steel pot under tap opening it in full swing.

He threw the handkerchief away avoiding it spreading anywhere else unaware that the flames got the red roses behind him ... the flames rose up completely swallowing the redness of roses and gradually fizzle out ...

And when saw that the situation was under control , placed his hands on her knees breathing heavily.

His eyes closed for a brief moment amidst the chaos.

Then he heard it. ---- A faint sob. So quiet that it almost drowned beneath the noise. His gaze searched the room and stopped. There she was.

Curled up in the corner beneath the shelf, pressed tightly against the wall as if she wished she could disappear into it. Her arms were wrapped around her knees, holding them desperately against her chest. Her face had lost all color. Trembling legs refused to stay still, and her shoulders shook with silent cries.

For a second, his heart dropped.

"Hey... hey..." He hurried toward her, crouching beside her. **"What happened?"**

As though his voice had startled her from somewhere far away. Slowly, she looked up. ... Her eyes were red and swollen, but it wasn't the tears that unsettled him.....It was the fear.---Pure.---Raw.---Terrifying fear. The kind that made a person look as though they were seeing something no one else could.

"Huriya..."

Her lips parted.

"So... sorr..." The words broke apart beneath her sobs.

"No, no." His voice softened immediately. **"It's okay. You don't need to apologize."**
A fresh wave of tears escaped her.

"It's okay..." he repeated helplessly, wishing he knew what had scared her so badly.
Her breathing grew faster.... Short.....Shallow.....Panicked.

"Huriya, look at me." She tried.
Failed. Tried again.

Without thinking further, he gently pulled her toward him.
For a moment she stiffened.... Then the fight seemed to leave her body all at once.
He wrapped his arms around her trembling frame, one hand settling on the back of her head with knuckles having redness by the bowling water that just stung his hand.

"Shhh..." he whispered. **"You're safe.... I am here"**
A sob escaped her.

"You're safe."

His shirt quickly dampened with tears as she buried her face against his chest, clutching the fabric with shaking fingers....

A small flames was still taking its last breath on one of the dark red rose over a red part ...
slowly it fizzles out .. the redness started to narrow down to a smaller and smaller circle
with the burning darkness spreading around ... and then it completely burnt out , leaving no
shade of red there... ..

leaving a bucket of burnt black roses there

----- see you in the next chapter :) -----